

providence has followed, whether it was the providence of stumbling on that *Fortune* magazine article on the mutual fund industry way back when I was searching for a topic for my senior thesis, and then committing myself wholeheartedly to the project; the providence (yes, the providence!) of being fired by my Wellington partners that demanded of me the commitment to recapture my career in the industry and gave me the opportunity to start Vanguard; the providence of receiving a new heart, just as mine was about to expire; and the commitment to making the most of my second chance at life; and the many other examples I've cited throughout this book—the “acres of diamonds” that were always providentially there, waiting to be discovered but requiring commitment to capitalize on their value.

Equally, for every act of boldness at Vanguard, I have indeed been rewarded with gifts of genius, power, and magic—not my own, but the genius, power, and magic of my fellow crew members and of the ideas that drove us on: building a better mousetrap and finding that clients would beat a path to our door, slashing costs, and investing for the long term, firmly committed to doing it all the right way, even when shortcuts were popping up all around us.

My inherent resistance to shortcuts was greatly amplified by a hard experience as a police-beat reporter for the old *Philadelphia Bulletin*. In 1950, while working at a summer job, I got a call from the news desk to cover a house fire that was two trolley rides away from my location in a firehouse. (I had no car.) It was about midnight; I was tired and uninspired by the story; so I waited until the firemen returned, got the story from them, and called it in. But my rewrite man, observing my lack of detail and sensing my strategy, caught me short with a single question: “What color was the house, Bogle?” Mortified by my conduct and scared that I might lose my job, I replied simply: “I’ll get over there right away.” And I did. It was a great lesson—I owe that rewrite man a hearty salute!—to beware of the apparently easy shortcuts of life. *If a job is to be done, best to do it right.*

Commitment and boldness—these are among the things that truly matter, the things by which we can measure our lives, the things that